



**MUKHERJEE WITH
INDIA TODAY EDITOR
PRABHU CHAWLA**

Let me now turn to the role of government in India. The government has to play the role of initiator, regulator and facilitator of change in varying degrees depending upon the internal and external environment. In a broad sense, governance can be broken into two levels. At an aggregate level, the purpose of governance is to provide an environment that supports and encourages private initiative in a non-discriminatory and inclusive manner. At an individual level, it is concerned with provision of basic services universally to all citizens. The NREGS, Bharat Nirman and the Right to Information Act are such initiatives.

At the international level, we need to reorient the growth paradigm. It is all the more critical because the developing countries still have positive growth rates and can provide the basis for global economic recovery. In these difficult times, it will be short-sighted to go into protectionist mode. That the biggest economy in the world, the US, where this global financial tsunami originated, should be resorting to

trade-restrictive practices is disturbing. The US Government's stimulus package imposing restrictions on public procurement or discouraging US firms from outsourcing or restricting hiring of foreign workers is not in keeping with the spirit of global cooperation.

Of the many challenges of change today which governments have to manage, one of the most important is terrorism. States that have used terror as an instrument of state policy should be left with no choice but to dismantle their infrastructure of terrorism and actively cooperate with the international community to eliminate this scourge. As this week's reprehensible attack on Sri Lankan cricketers in Lahore shows, the government's lack of will or capability in tackling this menace becomes a major hindrance in the process of change.

In conclusion, India's own historical experience as a modern nation demonstrates that the government has played a critical and pivotal role in the management of change. This has been possible, also, due to the nature of the relationship between civil society and the government. Today as we move ahead on a high growth rate trajectory, we are sure about the efficacy of the India model of economic growth: unique in world history. Our socially equitable economic growth has taken place within a democratic framework which was used not only for wealth creation, but also for wealth distribution. The concern for *aam admi* is central to this philosophy of inclusive growth.

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DISCUSSION

Q. In the last five years, on fundamental issues like security, infrastructure, power, education, health, the record of your Government has been poor. Why should we vote for you?

A. Performance is always relative. You ought to compare with whom you want to cast your vote and with whom you want to entrust the responsibility of running the government. I leave it to the judgement of 700 million electors who are going to cast their vote in five phases.

Q. There are two major requirements to bring about changes today. First is the calibre of our political leaders. Second, from the security point of view, police reforms are very essential. Unfortunately both NDA and UPA have taken no initiatives. Do you think the Opposition and the government can work together to bring about these changes?

A. Firstly, our population-police ratio is abnormally low compared to any other country. But I am not going to find any excuses. Mod-

ernisation of police forces, improvement of their mobility, equipping them with modern techniques is absolutely necessary. Political parties sometimes respond to people's urge and demand. Secondly, political parties may not give tickets but that doesn't prevent a chargesheeted person from contesting elections because every citizen who is not otherwise disqualified can seek election.

Q. This ministry is the largest ever with 72 ministers, 33 of them of Cabinet rank. Indira

Gandhi ran the country with only 42 ministers. Are you paying the price of a coalition? The number of secretaries then was 300, now it is 700.

A. If you have a clear two-thirds majority, the leaders are not susceptible to manoeuvrings. It's not the same with a large coalition government without adequate support on the floor of the House. Also, the complexities of the administration have increased. Look at the population. There were 35 crore people once. It's 112 crore now.